Journey Map / Service Blueprint

Product Proposal: Protection Order Petition Pre-Submission Checker

AI for Impact (CS 4535 / CS 6983), Fall 2026 | Team 10 | Client: Indiana Supreme Court, Office of Judicial Administration

Team 10	Details
Group members	Yash Kava, Michael Hernandez, Prachi Bhavsar, Udit Sen, Leonardo Pivato, Vashistha Ravindra Pandya, Joythish Reddy Evuri
This week's lead	Yash Kava
Case type	Civil protection order (domestic violence), Indiana Civil Protection Order Act, Ind. Code § 34-26-5
Lens	Litigant side (petitioner). A court-side track will follow using the same method (Section 9).
Date	October 27, 2026

1. Product Decision

We will build a pre-submission checker for Indiana protection order petitions that gives self-filers the review an in-person protective order specialist gives at the counter.

It flags, in plain language, the court's own published reasons emergency orders are denied: facts that don't meet the legal definition, vague time, place or acts, secondhand accounts without affidavits, and missing respondent details.

It also prepares evidence photos for upload (resize, strip location data) and never tells the user what to claim.

On the maps below, the problem we are fixing is outlined in red and marked ★.

2. Problem Statement

People asking Indiana courts for a protection order often submit petitions that do not contain the facts the law requires: one incident where stalking needs two, descriptions with no date or place, or events they only heard about from someone else. Judges then deny emergency (ex parte) orders that might otherwise have been granted, and the petitioner, who may still be in danger, has to start over. Allen County prevents many of these denials with a dedicated protective order specialist who reviews petitions and follows up, but most counties have no such role, and people who e-file late at night from a phone never meet one.

Why this problem, and not another

We compared four candidate problems against the evidence we have. Incomplete or insufficient petitions had the strongest support: the court publishes the denial reasons itself (S1), and both magistrates described denials of this kind as routine, including one issued the morning of our client session (S2). Oversized evidence files (the example raised in class) are a real friction point but our walkthrough has not yet confirmed the actual upload limit, so we treat it as a supporting feature. Missing respondent details are folded into the core check. Difficulty finding help in the first place is important context but would be a different product.

LASSO check

Test	How this problem meets it
Limited	One case type (protection orders), one moment (before submission), one failure (petition lacks legally required facts).
Actionable	The denial reasons are written down by the court (S1), so each can become a specific, testable check.
Specific	Named checks: relationship fit, two-incident stalking rule, time/place/act detail, secondhand accounts, respondent identifiers.
Supported	Raised unprompted by both magistrates and by the Director of E-filing in our client session (S2); the court is already investing in a redesigned protection order e-filing site (S2, S9).
Owner	Indiana OJA, Office of Court Technology, which runs the Protection Order E-filing Service (S4, S8).

Scale and stakes

Indiana trial courts received 75,256 new protective order and other petition filings in 2025 (S11). Allen County alone handled about 4,200 protective orders last year (S2). An ex parte order can be granted the same day without notice to the respondent when a petition shows domestic or family violence (S1), so a denial caused by missing detail directly delays protection. The proceedings carry no filing fee (S1), which means cost is not the barrier; information is.

3. Persona

Persona	Details
Name	Dana Morales, 31 (composite persona)
Where	Kokomo, Howard County, Indiana. We assume her county has no dedicated protective order specialist (to be verified).
Situation	Dated the respondent for two years and broke up three months ago. Since then he has sent repeated threatening texts, shown up at her workplace twice, and last week grabbed her arm and shoved her in a parking lot.
Constraints	Works rotating shifts as a nursing assistant and cannot easily take time off. Uses her phone for everything. Has 14 screenshots and photos as evidence. Knows the respondent’s name and address, but not his exact date of birth.
Goal	Get an order that keeps him away from her home and work, as quickly and quietly as possible.
What goes wrong	Her petition says “he has been harassing me for months and pushed me,” gives no dates or places, and describes the workplace visits through what a coworker told her. The judge denies the ex parte order as too vague.

4. Journey Map: Dana files for a protection order

Starts before the service begins and ends after the outcome. Times are estimates to be replaced with our measured walkthrough times; nothing was submitted. Tags: **K** = Known (documented), **H** = Heard (client session), **A** = Assumed. Source codes refer to Section 11.

Stage	What Dana does	Touchpoint	Thinking / feeling	Pain point	Time (est.)	Tag and source
1. Trigger	Is shoved in a parking lot after weeks of texts and two workplace visits. Decides that night she needs legal protection.	None yet	"I can't keep waiting for this to stop." Scared, exhausted.	Acts late at night, alone, under stress, with no one to ask.	Day 0	A: persona scenario
2. Search	Searches "how to get a restraining order Indiana" on her phone; reads an AI chatbot answer and search results.	Phone search, general AI chatbot	Confused by mixed terms and out-of-state advice.	Indiana calls it an "order for protection," not a restraining order. General AI tools are used far more than official help sites.	15–20 min	K: S1 terminology. H: S2, people find ChatGPT about 100 to 1 over Indiana Legal Help
3. Find official path	Reaches the Indiana courts self-service protection order page; sees she can file online or go through an advocate.	courts.in.gov	Relieved it is free, unsure whether she needs an advocate.	Advocates are recommended but she can't reach one tonight or leave work tomorrow.	10 min	K: S3, S4
4. Look for guided help	Tries Indiana Legal Help for a guided interview.	indianalegalhelp.org	"Where is the step-by-step?"	No protection order guided interview; the page links back to the courts' tutorial and resources.	5–10 min	K: S6
5. Start the petition	Opens the Protection Order E-filing Service, creates an account, chooses the petition for herself.	PO E-filing Service (phone)	Long forms on a small screen.	Forms mirror the statute and are long; the e-filing site follows the forms.	15 min	K: S7. H: S2, Janelle O'Malley on form length
6. Respondent details	Enters his name and address; leaves date of birth blank.	Petition + Confidential Form	"I don't know his birthday exactly."	Without DOB or SSN the order can't enter the national registry (still valid in Indiana).	5 min	K: S1
7. Describe what happened ★ **PROBLEM WE ARE FIXING:** vague, secondhand narrative	Writes "he has been harassing me for months and pushed me." Describes the workplace visits as her coworker told them. No dates or places.	Petition narrative fields	"The judge will understand." Doesn't want to relive details.	Nothing on the page tells her that vague allegations and secondhand accounts without an affidavit are common reasons for denial. At the Allen County counter, a specialist would.	20–30 min	K: S1 denial reasons. H: S2, Magistrates Cook and Beaty
8. Attach evidence	Tries to upload 14 full-size screenshots and photos.	Upload screen	Frustrated when uploads stall on mobile data.	Upload limit for this system not yet confirmed; photos may carry location data.	15+ min	A: limit to test in walkthrough. K: S5 general e-filing limits are 50 MB per document
9. Submit and wait	Submits and waits for an acceptance email.	Email	"Did it go through?"	The service tells filers to call the clerk if no acceptance email arrives within several days.	1–3 days	K: S7
10. Judge review ★ **PROBLEM WE ARE FIXING:** preventable denial	Receives notice that the ex parte order was denied.	Denial order	Shock, fear, self-blame.	Denied because allegations lacked time, place, and acts. The filing was accepted by the clerk but denied on the merits, a distinction she doesn't understand.	1–3 days	K: S1. H: S2, Judge Cook denied a similar e-filed petition the morning of our session
11. After denial	Must re-file with more detail or go to court in person, taking time off work. May give up.	Clerk's office, phone	"Is it even worth it?"	Delay while still at risk; repeat work for her and the court.	Days	A: to validate with Bob Rath and advocates

5. Service Blueprint: protection order petition, staff perspective

Five lanes: physical evidence, petitioner actions, frontstage (line of interaction), backstage (line of visibility), and support processes. Every box carries a tag and source.

Lane	1. Search and prepare	2. Complete and submit	3. Clerk review	4. Judge review	5. Order and service	6. Registry and enforcement
Physical evidence	Search results; courts.in.gov protection order page; instruction booklet. K: S1, S3	Web forms: Petition, Confidential Form, Notice of Exclusion; uploaded photos. K: S1, S7	Acceptance or rejection email. K: S7	Signed ex parte order, hearing notice, or denial order. K: S1	Served copy of petition and order. K: S1	Order in Indiana Protection Order Registry; optional text and email alerts. K: S3
Petitioner actions	Searches on phone; reads instructions; decides to e-file alone. A: persona	Fills forms, writes narrative, uploads evidence, submits. K: S1, S7	Waits; calls clerk if no email in several days. K: S7	Waits; if denied, re-files or goes in person. A	Carries copies; shares with employer and school. K: S1	Signs up for notifications of service and status. K: S3
Frontstage (line of interaction)	Website content, “Find an Advocate,” Safe Exit button. K: S3, S7	E-filing interface collects fields but does not review the narrative for required facts. H: S2	Clerk’s accept or reject notice. H: S2, Janelle O’Malley	Judge’s written order. K: S1	Sheriff serves respondent in person. H: S2, Judge Cook	Automated notifications. K: S3
Backstage (line of visibility)	Advocates (YWCA, ICADV) interview and draft petitions for those who reach them. K: S3	No staff review before submission for e-filers. A: confirm with Bob Rath	Clerk reviews filing in Odyssey File and Serve queue; accepts and forwards to judge. K: S7. H: S2	★ **PROBLEM WE ARE FIXING:** No specialist Judge checks petition against statutory definitions. In Allen County a specialist follows up on incomplete petitions and holds them 24 hours; most counties lack this role. H: S2, Magistrate Beaty. A: other counties	Sheriff’s civil division attempts personal service. H: S2	Registry transmits order to IDACS and NCIC. K: S8
Support processes	Indiana Legal Help (no PO guided interview); Self-Service Legal Center. K: S6, S3	Protection Order E-filing Service, run by Court Technology since Oct 2019. K: S8	Odyssey statewide case management system. H: S2, Bob Rath	Standardized statewide PO forms; Legal Information vs. Legal Advice guide for staff. K: S8. H: S2	Sheriff’s department; no service fees charged. K: S1	Indiana Protection Order Registry; IDACS / NCIC. K: S1, S8

Where our product sits: between stages 2 and 3, on the petitioner’s side of the line of interaction, filling the backstage gap marked ★ for people who file without a specialist or advocate.

6. Proposed Solution

The checker runs on a draft petition before it is filed through the official Protection Order E-filing Service. The person pastes or uploads their draft, selects the basis they are filing under, and receives a short plain-language report: what is complete, what the court commonly denies petitions for, and which facts appear to be missing. They edit their own draft and re-run the check as many times as they want. The tool does not file anything; the person still submits through the official service.

How it works

The product is a short agentic pipeline in which rules decide and the language model only reads and rephrases. This keeps every flag traceable to a published court source, which the client asked for (algorithmic transparency).

1. **Read the draft.** Accept typed text, a pasted narrative, or the PDF of the petition.
2. **Extract incidents.** The language model turns the narrative into a structured list: what happened, when, where, and who witnessed it.
3. **Apply the basis the user chose.** The user selects domestic violence, stalking, harassment, or sex offense; the tool never recommends one.
4. **Run rule checks.** Deterministic checks built from the court's published denial reasons (S1) run against the structured list.
5. **Fix mechanical problems automatically.** Resize oversized photos while keeping text readable, and strip embedded location data.
6. **Ask, don't tell.** Return each substantive gap as a fixed, pre-reviewed message or a question, such as "Is there another incident you have not listed?"

Example checks

Check	Triggered when	Message the user sees	Source
Stalking incidents	Stalking selected and fewer than two incidents described	"Stalking requires two or more incidents. Your petition describes one."	S1, S2
Time, place, acts	An incident has no date, location, or description of what was done	"Incident 1 doesn't say when or where it happened. Petitions can be denied when allegations don't describe the time, place, or acts."	S1
Secondhand accounts	Narrative describes events the petitioner did not see ("my coworker said…")	"This part describes something another person saw. Accounts from other people need a sworn affidavit from that person, who must also attend any hearing."	S1
Relationship fit	Domestic violence selected but relationship not in the statutory list	"Domestic violence orders cover family or household members, such as current or former partners. The relationship described isn't one of those listed."	S1
Harassment only	Harassment is the only basis	"Petitions based only on harassment require notice to the respondent and a hearing within 30 days before any order is issued."	S1
Respondent details	No date of birth or Social Security number	"Without the respondent's date of birth or Social Security number, the order can't be entered into the national registry. It will still be in the Indiana registry."	S1
Evidence files	Photo exceeds upload limit or carries GPS data	"This photo was resized to fit the upload limit and its text is still readable. Location data was removed."	A, S5

7. Guardrails

Legal information, not legal advice

Every message states a requirement or asks a question; none tells the user what they should claim, which case to use, or whether they will win. We apply the test Janelle O'Malley gave us: any message phrased as "you should" is advice and is rewritten or removed (S2). Each message is also checked against Indiana's Legal Information vs. Legal Advice guide. The two-incident message matches what Judge Cook said his staff can already tell people at the counter (S2).

Privacy and safety

- Drafts are processed in the session only: nothing is stored, logged, or used to train a model.
- A visible Safe Exit button and no saved history, for people using a shared or monitored device.
- Location data is stripped from photos before upload, since the petition is a public document that is sent to the respondent (S1).
- The tool never contacts the respondent, the court, or anyone else, and never files on the user's behalf.

Out of scope

Writing the narrative for the user, recommending a basis or legal strategy, predicting outcomes, filing, case types other than protection orders, and the court-side review of AI-generated filings (Section 9).

8. Success Measures and Assumptions

How we will know it works

- Detection: on a test set of at least 30 fictional petitions, each seeded with one or more documented denial reasons, the checker flags at least 90% of the seeded problems.
- Precision: complete petitions produce few or no false flags; we report the false-flag rate alongside detection.
- Boundary: zero messages fail the "should" test in team and faculty review.
- Usability: in think-aloud tests, testers can explain what each flag means and what fact is missing without help.
- Long term (pilot, with the court): fewer ex parte denials for vague or incomplete petitions among users, if the court can measure it.

Assumptions we still need to test

Assumption	Why it matters	How we will test it
Denials for insufficient facts are common outside Allen County.	Determines how much value the tool adds statewide.	Ask Bob Rath and clerks in counties without a specialist.
The Protection Order E-filing Service has an upload limit that phone photos exceed.	Decides whether the evidence feature is needed.	Upload test during our walkthrough, without submitting.
Attachments are sent to the respondent with the petition.	Makes location stripping a safety requirement, not a convenience.	Ask Bob Rath and Janelle O'Malley.
The court would treat our messages as legal information.	Required for adoption.	Review messages with Bob Rath against the court's guide.
The redesigned protection order site doesn't already include these checks.	Avoids duplicating the court's own work.	Ask Janelle O'Malley about the redesign's scope.
People would run a check before filing.	A tool no one uses fixes nothing.	Think-aloud tests with the persona scenario.

9. Court-Side Track

Half of the team will define a court-side problem using the same method: evidence first, then a three-line decision. The leading candidate from our client session is the growing volume of long, AI-generated motions from self-represented parties, some citing authority that doesn't exist, which judges described as multiplying their review time (S2). Indiana's revised Trial Rules 11 and 11.2, effective August 1, 2026, now treat citing fictitious legal authority as sanctionable conduct, which gives that track a concrete rule to anchor to. The court-side proposal will be submitted separately once the team has evidence for it.

10. Next Steps

When	What
By Oct 30	Finish timed walkthrough and replace estimated times on the journey map. Turn each denial reason in the instruction booklet into a written rule with one approved message.
Oct 30 – Nov 3	Write 30+ fictional test petitions covering every check, plus complete petitions as controls. Sketch the low-fidelity flow: paste draft, see report, answer questions, fix photos.
Nov 3 – 6	Prototype the extraction step and rule checks on the test set. Prepare the walkthrough for Prototype Review on November 6.
Ongoing	Send open assumptions to Bob Rath and Colin Rule as part of our questions for them.

11. Sources

S1. Indiana Office of Court Services, Instructions for Petition for Order of Protection, Filed by Person Seeking Protection (OJA-PO-0102, rev. 05/25). https://www.in.gov/courts/iocs/files/center-bb-po-form-po-0102.pdf

S2. AI for Impact client session with Bob Rath (Chief Innovation Officer), Janelle O'Malley (Director of E-filing and Innovation), Magistrate Brian Cook and Magistrate Taylor Beaty (Allen County), October 9, 2026. Class transcript.

S3. Indiana Judicial Branch, Self-Service Legal Center: Getting a Protection Order. https://www.in.gov/courts/selfservice/protection-orders

S4. Indiana Judicial Branch, E-filing Protection Orders. https://secure.in.gov/courts/help/efiling/protection-orders

S5. Indiana Judicial Branch, E-filing User Guide (updated September 1, 2026). https://www.in.gov/courts/files/efiling-user-guide.pdf

S6. Indiana Legal Help, Protection Order Resources and Information. https://indianalegalhelp.org/protection-order/

S7. Indiana Protection Order E-filing Service. https://public.courts.in.gov/porefsp

S8. Indiana Court Times, "Change for the Better: Protection Orders & Electronic Filing" (2019). https://times.courts.in.gov/2019/12/20/change-for-the-better-protection-orders-electronic-filing

S9. Indiana Court Times, "Writing a New Chapter" (2025), on the INfile platform and the planned redevelopment of protection order e-filing. https://times.courts.in.gov/2025/08/06/writing-a-new-chapter

S10. Wisconsin Court System, online portal pilot for domestic abuse restraining order petitions (field scan comparable), July 22, 2026. https://www.wicourts.gov/news/view.jsp?id=1776

S11. Indiana Supreme Court, 2026-10 briefing for AI for Impact students: summary of 2025 new filings (provisional data).

12. AI Use

AI Use Disclosure. In line with the course policy on responsible AI use, our team used Claude (Anthropic), provided through Northeastern University, to support this submission. We used it to review our course materials and client-session transcript, research Indiana's protection order process and court rules, and organize our findings into the journey map, service blueprint, and proposal structure. It also helped draft and edit the text. Every claim in the document is tied to a numbered source, and the team reviewed the cited sources and the full draft for accuracy. Items we could not verify are tagged as Assumed. The problem selection, product decision, and final content are the team's own, and we take full responsibility for the work as submitted.